

A FEMALE ROBINSON CRUSOE

A True Tale of the Santa Barbara Islands

BY O. M. PAUL

IN SOLITUDE and utter loneliness a bleak sentinel on the vast stretches of the Pacific Ocean, with no sound save the roar of the seething breakers as they play in wild abandon on its rugged cliffs the farthest outpost of the shores of Southern California, lies the little island of San Nicholas, some thirty miles beyond its nearest neighbor. With this and a few others, the whole group comprises the Santa Barbara Islands. At one time they were quite rich in seals, sea otters and abalone shells, but now they are sparsely settled and rarely a wanderer drifts to San Nicholas Island. However, it was not always uninhabited. At the time of the discovery of California all the islands were quite thickly populated. The people were a superior race, with white skin, light hair and rosy cheeks. As the early settlers coming from Europe increased, the native population fell off. A few years later, Franciscan monks from Spain founded missions in many parts of Southern California, first converting and then utilizing the native Indians. Some time later they brought the inhabitants of all the nearer islands in a body to the mainland, and in 1835 the entire population of San Nicholas, hitherto left in peace, because of its distance, was also transported. It was at this time that the event occurred which the writer gives verbatim as told him by an old English sailor on the water front of New York City, at the time reporter on a daily journal of the great metropolis. The story was substantiated by an old log-book in the possession of the sailorman.

One sunny morning in the month of April, of the year 1835, all of Santa Barbara crowded to the shores of the bay to enjoy the rare spectacle of a ship sailing out of the harbor. Even the pious monks left their customary employment in the garden to mingle with the curious throng at the beach.

The attraction was the little ship *Peor Es Nada*, a trim schooner of 25 tons, that had been chartered by two Americans for hunting sea otter along the coast of Lower California. Three months later, after a successful cruise, they entered the harbor of San Pedro, disposed of their skins, and at once set sail for San Nicholas. This in compliance with the commission of the missionaries to convey its inhabitants to their domain. Before the little schooner reached the island, the weather changed, and a fierce storm threatened. After considerable difficulty a landing was effected. As the wind increased rapidly, it was feared the ship might wreck on the jagged cliffs and the embarking of the natives was hurriedly accomplished. Immediately the vessel prepared to leave the dangerous neighborhood of the island to seek the safety of a sheltering harbor. At the very moment of the departure, one of the women missed her baby, which she thought had been carried on board by one of the sailors. Weeping and with heart-breaking lamentations, she begged to be allowed to go on shore again.

However, as it was now blowing a gale, not daring to lose a moment, as the least delay might cause the destruction of all, the Captain gave the

command to put off, assuring the broken-hearted mother that immediately after the storm, probably the very next morning, he would return. When the poor mother realized that her pleading was in vain, and the vessel was leaving the island, with a despairing shriek she jumped into the boiling sea. She was seen to battle with the breakers, then was soon lost to sight. Nothing could possibly be done in such an angry sea toward her rescue.

After a tempestuous voyage, the schooner reached San Pedro. There the San Nicholas Islanders, never to return to their home, were landed, and were distributed among the missions of Los Angeles and San Gabriel.

The captain was sincere in his intention to return to the island and learn the fate of the poor woman and her child, but the craft was needed so urgently for other purposes that humanity was forced to withdraw before business, and as the ill-fated schooner had the misfortune to wreck on the next trip, no possible means of reaching the island offered, since at that time the coast of Southern California could boast of nothing larger than a fisherman's yawl, and no one would venture in an open boat. Indeed, there was little hope that the woman had reached land, the indications being that she had been drowned in the breakers, while the infant, thus abandoned, could not possibly survive its mother; therefore, the affair was soon forgotten.

Not entirely, however, as among the monks in the mission of Santa Barbara was a certain Father Gonzales, whom the fate of the unfortunate mother affected very deeply. He spared no pains to obtain certainty relative to it; nevertheless, it was 15 years before he was able to find a person who would consent to go to San Nicholas Island and search for proof on the spot. A skipper named Thomas Jeffries, who had just had a small schooner built for himself, was guaranteed \$200 for the trip. Jeffries searched the entire island, and though

signs of human habitation were not lacking, for he found a hut of whalebone, a number of stone utensils, some of which, among them a beautiful cup of serpentine, he took with him, he discovered nothing that would lead to the belief the woman was alive and on the island.

On his return, San Nicholas Island was again a favorite subject, and not long after a second expedition sailed for it, though with a different object. Jeffries had related of having seen, outside of numerous foxes and wild dogs, an almost inconceivable amount of seals and sea otters. His description aroused the intense interest of a number of hunters, so the following spring a small party under the leadership of Captain George Nidiver, and accompanied by Jeffries, set sail for the island. Arriving there they anchored at the southern end. Climbing to the top of the cliffs, they had a magnificent view of the endless stretches of the ocean, horizon to horizon. But neither the grandeur of the water nor the wild beauty of the island produced the effect that the many rocks did, literally covered with black seals and the numberless fissures alive with otter. Scarce taking time to erect suitable tents, the men began the slaughter. For six weeks they remained on the prolific shores, employing the entire time with seal killing and otter trapping.

They had neither the time nor inclination to explore the interior of the island, a spring bubbling out of an adjacent rock furnished sufficient fresh water, everything else having been provided beforehand.

At one time during the last few days of their stay, while resting because of a severe storm, one of the men claimed to have seen on a distant exposed rock far in the interior, a woman's figure, which appeared to run back and forth and to try to hail him. When in response to the man's shouting the captain came, the figure had disappeared. In Santa Barbara, on the arrival of the party, the story quickly spread, and the ghost of San Nicholas was for a

long time a favorite topic among the superstitious.

In July, another party left the island with Captain Nidiver again at the helm. Among them was a certain Charles Detman, a fisherman known as Charley Brown, an Irish cook, also a number of Indians from the Missions.

This time the destination was the northern end of the island. Immediately after anchoring, Nidiver and Brown started on a jaunt along the shore, though only for pleasure. The night being warm and the full moon very bright, they wandered further than they had intended. Suddenly, Nidiver stood still, glanced about in all directions, then knelt down to examine something that had attracted his attention. What he saw was the clearly defined imprint of a human foot. Eureka! the ghost of San Nicholas was real, the woman was still alive. On making this discovery the excitement of the men was intense. Without signaling to the rest of the party, they at once began search. They called loudly that they were friends and had come to help her. But although they walked and called for hours, they neither saw nor heard anything. The next day they found hanging on the limb of a tree a basket made of rush containing some bone needles, twine made of twisted fish gut, fish hooks of shell, and an unfinished dress of bird skins. Brown advised throwing the things under the tree to ascertain if they would be picked up. This was done. Further in the interior they discovered circular enclosures, constructed of dovetailed branches. Nearly clean-hewed posts had been driven in the earth, having cross-pieces high above the ground, on which were hung dried meats. Likewise they found dried fish and seal fat, stored away in crevices near the springs. Yet nowhere a sign of the woman herself. However, that someone, whether the woman or the child, grown up, had lately been on the island, was proven beyond a doubt. Searching for many days without further success, and the articles thrown out of the basket not having been

picked up, the foot-prints also proving to be older than at first supposed, they finally came to the conclusion that no living being existed there any more, and returned to the business which had brought them. In a few weeks they had finished, and were preparing for the return trip. Old Nidiver, however, could not forget the poor, abandoned soul. He proposed to the party that they should make one more search in every part of the island, to find if possible, at least, her remains. Refusing at first to waste their time on such a fruitless mission, he finally, though with great difficulty, persuaded them—and so now the entire party scoured the island, "seeking a ghost," as they said.

After several days, Charley Brown found the whale bone hut, in which lay several implements, but the grass around it bore no traces of disturbance. Climbing up a towering promontory further toward the interior, he discovered fresh footprints that were, however, soon lost in the moss. Going to the edge he saw his companions far below him. Coming back to examine further, he suddenly became aware of a strange movement at some distance, but could not make out what caused it. Gliding closer, as silently as possible, he soon perceived the head of a woman that just showed above the bushes. Carefully approaching to within a few feet, he saw what he had supposed to be bushes was the wall of a roofless hut, built of strong branches intertwined. In the hut was what appeared to be a couch of grass, several pots, a knife rudely fashioned out of a barrel hoop with a wooden handle, also a steadily burning fire, with some bones in the ashes.

The woman's skin was lighter in hue than most Indians, her features were very regular and pleasing, and her brown hair hung in thick braids over her shoulders. Talking incessantly to herself, her eyes shaded with her hands, she was gazing at the foot of the rocks. She had not yet seen the men below. Brown, fearing to frighten her if he called, endeavored to attract

her attention by placing his hat on the ramrod of his gun and raising it up and down. This signal, however, was seen by the men, so Brown by further signals, gave them to understand that they should surround the place and then climb up, thus preventing the woman's possible flight.

Before the men came up, he approached the woman and spoke to her. She started back in fear, seemed anxious to run away, but evidently changed her mind, for she stood perfectly still, then spoke to Brown in a strange tongue. She appeared to be between 40 and 50 years old, of sturdy build and erect stature; her face was also well marked with wrinkles. She was dressed in a sort of cloth made of bird skins that reached to her ankles, her arms being bare. As Brown's companions neared, she greeted them in a simple but dignified manner that impressed both the white men and the Indians. She then busied herself to prepare a meal for them from her scanty store, which consisted only of roasted roots. The Indians in the party spoke a number of dialects, but none could converse with the new-found hermit nor understand what she said. Made to comprehend by pantomime that they wished her to accompany them, she was at once ready. Her few possessions were packed into the baskets; these the men carried, she taking a burning brand from the fire, followed the men to the shore. Without hesitation she stepped into the boat, and thence onto the schooner.

Brown, wishing to save her dress of birdskin, made her a petticoat of a piece of canvas, also gave her a man's cotton shirt and a colored neck-cloth. During Brown's dressmaking efforts she observed him closely, and was amused at the way he operated his needle. Then she showed him how she first punched the holes with the bone needle and then drew the thread through them. Realizing soon, however, that Brown's method was speedier, she expressed the wish to sew in like manner, whereupon he gave her his needle, instructing her how to thread.

Her first efforts were very clumsy, but she soon became quite proficient. While sewing she told various episodes from her lonely life on the island as well as she could without the aid of speech. The poor, lone woman had from time to time seen vessels sailing by, had hoped and prayed that they would come and take her with them, and then had sadly seen them disappear in the far distance. Then she had despaired, and thrown herself on the ground, screaming in the agony of her abandonment. However in time she had become more resigned. On a few occasions men had landed, but in her fear she had always hid away until they were gone, though later she was sorry. If Brown had not surprised her it would have been the same way, but now she was very glad to get back to her tribe that had gone away so many years ago with the white people.

Crossing her arms on her breast and sucking her thumb with a sad look in her eyes and a pathetic hush movement of her arms, she gave them to understand that she had had a baby at the time, but when she swam ashore after leaping from the vessel she could not find it, though she sought everywhere. For days she had lain on the ground, wailing and weeping in her hopeless grief. Her food all this time was a few leaves of a species of wild cabbage that grew there. When more composed, she had managed by rubbing a pointed stick along a narrow groove in a flat piece of wood, after many unsuccessful attempts, to start a fire, which she was most careful to keep alive. On her tramps she had always taken a burning brand with her, and had never failed to cover her fire in the hut with ashes. She had lived on fish, seal fat, shell meat and roots. The birds, the skins of which had furnished her for the material for her dress, she had caught at night in the crevices of the rocks. Her principal dwelling place was a rocky cove at the northern end of the island, but she had also at different places built enclosures where she could spend the night secure from storms and wild beasts. At these

places she had also provided a supply of dried meats, hung on poles, beyond the reach of the wild dogs and other animals.

During the voyage home, a severe storm came up. The woman signified that she wished to calm the inclement weather. Turning her face to windward, she mumbled some words, and her joy, when the sky cleared, demonstrated that she ascribed it to the power of her charm. Just as the schooner dropped anchor in Santa Barbara, a wagon drawn by a team of oxen, rolled by, a sight that quite frightened the poor woman. On the other hand, a horse and rider were a source of delight to her. She affectionately stroked the horse, and proceeded to satisfy herself that the rider was not grown to the horse. Beckoning to her late shipmates, she described to them the wonderful spectacle, endeavoring to illustrate by placing two fingers of her right hand over the thumb of her left and giving them a swinging motion.

Captain Didiver's residence was the center of attraction for the many curious and interested people who wished to see the stranger, reclaimed from the dead. Even two speculative showmen proposed to the captain that he lease the woman to them, in order that they might exhibit her in San Francisco. But Captain Nidiver was too honorable to wish to profit through the misfortune of his guest, and refused all offers.

The poor woman manifested a remarkable affection for Nidiver's children. She caressed and played with them for hours. Occasionally visitors gave her small presents, which as soon as the visitors were gone she instantly distributed among the children, laughing and supremely happy if only they were pleased.

Through the efforts of the fathers

in Santa Barbara, numbers of Indians were brought from different missions with the hope that there might be one among them who could understand her language, but the hope was in vain.

The inhabitants of San Nicholas, brought over eighteen years before, had been sent to various missions, and despite all efforts, not a trace of even one could be found. The poor woman, helpless and lonelier than ever among friends, was sorely disappointed and heart-broken when she realized that none of her tribe was left.

The change of living also affected her health seriously, and in a few months she had become so weak that she was unable to walk without assistance. Every day she was carried in her chair to the front of the door, where, sitting in the warm sun, she scanned every passer-by closely, as if still expecting and hoping to see a friend. Nothing was spared for her comfort, even seal fat was obtained and prepared in the ashes as she had done, thinking the accustomed food might do her good. She feebly tried to show her gratitude, but she could not eat it. One day she fell unconscious, and although she revived, it was only too evident that her last hour was approaching. The good Madame Nidiver sent for a priest, that her protegee might be baptized. In her dying hour, with the dull gray of death already mantling her sunken cheek, this first ceremony was sadly performed.

Juana Maria, as she was called, needed not this first passport to the Kingdom of Heaven, for the keen anguish and the endless sorrow of desolation this poor suffering exile endured in her unwilling banishment, surely purged her of all sin. Underneath a plain, simple mound in the old Mission graveyard at Santa Barbara, in eternal rest, sleeps the last of her race in peace.